

ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA



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and sponsors in STEM, resulting in many lacking the necessary guidance or inspiration. For many women, balancing work and family responsibilities poses yet another significant challenge—one that is common to women across all career trajectories. Traditional workplace structures often lack the flexibility needed to accommodate these dual roles. Without supportive policies, women are left navigating an uphill battle, hindering their ability to thrive in their careers.

The gender pay gap remains a reality in STEM fields. Women often receive lower pay than their male counterparts for similar roles, underscoring the systemic inequalities that need to be addressed. This disparity impacts financial independence and perpetuates the subtle notion that women's contributions in STEM are less valuable.

To tackle these ongoing issues, we must adopt a comprehensive strategy. Initiatives aimed at changing societal perceptions about gender roles can encourage girls to pursue STEM from a young age.

At workplaces, companies can have specialised recruitment programmes that are unbiased and give women an equal opportunity to become a part of the STEM workforce. Structured mentorship can provide women with the support and role models they need to navigate their careers and advance professionally. By addressing these issues with focussed initiatives and inclusive policies, we can create a more equitable environment. Empowering women in these fields not only benefits individuals but also strengthens the entire industry, driving innovation and progress for all.

As we stand on the brink of a new era, it is imperative that we transform potential into reality, ensuring that every woman has the opportunity to thrive in STEM. The future of our industries—and indeed, our society—depends on our collective commitment to bridging the gender gap. **BT**

Views are personal